

Killer Rigs

On a budget? Want to build a compact HTPC? Here's our list of perfect components to assemble your own PC

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A broken cooler, competitiveness and high-end overclocking demands take our agent to the land of hardware. Will he be able to find the right components for overclocking? Let's find out...

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When I say "Sleep eludes me", it's somewhat of an understatement as I find myself sitting and playing game after game through the night and not noticing the early morning birds chirping while I'm still at it. Be it the visually pleasing *Crysis 3* or the new *Tomb Raider*. One such morning I got a call from one of my long lost friends (long lost as in he never ever called me before) and when I picked up the phone, he shrieked like a little girl excited about her very first doll. He then bombarded me with questions about overclocking components without bothering to make the usual small talk "How are you? It's been a long time." etc. Well, we all have friends like that. However, gifted with a magnanimous nature, I took on the task

of helping the poor lad out with a gentle smile and soothing words.

It so happened that my friend was using a mid-range gaming PC for some time which he had mildly overclocked. He was fortunate enough to be on the receiving end of an unexpected wind-fall and decided to upgrade his rig, one overclocker-friendly beast that would blow away all competition.

I would have normally passed up this opportunity to go shopping with this "friend", but then remembered that I had a score to settle with a couple of my buddies at Digit. They had somehow managed to worm their way into 3DMark's hall of fame and their amateurish attempt needed to be put in its place. A severe lack of cooling had hampered their progress and it seemed like a good chance to go and pick up a nice cooler and "show 'em how it's done!"

A day before going, I got another call, and it was from my brother who unluckily, had broken his CPU cooler during regular maintenance. Instead of buying a cheap cooler, he thought it would be better to get a good cooler within a budget of ₹5000-₹6000 which would also allow him to overclock his CPU since he hadn't been able to realise the full potential of his 2500k yet. So I revealed to him my plan of going to Lamington Road and asked him to tag along (a familiar face would be nice

company). I also made a few notes about which components we needed to buy and what would fit in our respective budgets.

The day arrived and I reached on time as did my brother but my friend was nowhere to be seen, and then I remembered his old habit of always being late for everything. So my brother and I decided to kill some time by visiting a few of my favourite shops. A few years ago, any shopkeeper would be simply shocked to hear the words "liquid cooler." The widespread availability and demand for these coolers have now made these commonplace and shopkeepers now seem more familiar with these devices. Anyway, I made a mental note about which coolers we should think about going for. When we got out of a shop I spotted my friend at a nearby roadside stall looking at smartphone cases. Apparently, the cellphone cover was a way of making up with his girlfriend who was upset with him for being late at an important event. He settled for a BB case in such a hideous shade of pink, it would make Barbie nauseous. Me and my brother let out a collective sigh, steeled ourselves for the day ahead, and dragged him off to the nearest computer hardware store. Since he wanted to build a gaming rig (excluding the monitor, mouse, keyboard and speakers as he already had all of those) with a focus on overclocking, I had prepared a configuration for my friend that had a good motherboard – a prerequisite for any good PC made for overclocking – and a processor with an unlocked multiplier. The unlocked multiplier really helps when you want to reach high overlocks as you can tweak settings and set a higher multiplier. I also added a kit of fast RAM with 2000+ Mhz speeds and good timings as BCLK directly affects RAM speeds (discussed in the Workshop). Since his primary objective was gaming and overclocking, a good graphics card with a good cooling setup was selected. A nice power supply is equally important as overclocking needs stable power, so a modular PSU with 80+ efficiency was also chosen. The most important thing left was the CPU cooler; this will actually determine the thermal headroom you will have while overclocking, so I kept a few options for that in my mind also.